

two students kill 12 of their fellow students and a teacher before turning their guns on themselves.

2000 In the presidential election, Al Gore, the Democratic candidate, eventually concedes to Republican candidate George W. Bush, son of the former president. Gore receives more popular votes than Bush, but the contest is decided by a few thousand highly controversial ballots cast in Florida, home state of Governor Jeb Bush, George Bush's brother.

2000 The growth of the Internet fuels the booming economy, as shown by online service America Online's purchase of "old media" conglomerate Time Warner for \$160 billion in the largest corporate merger to date. By the end of the year, however, the so-called "Internet Bubble" has largely burst, driving many companies out of business and others (like AOL Time Warner) to suffer big drops in share value.

2001 9/11: In the world's worst terrorist attack, Al-Qaeda kills nearly 3,000 people as two hijacked planes are flown into the twin towers of the World Trade Center in New York and a third hits the Pentagon in Virginia. A fourth hijacked plane crash-lands in a field in Pennsylvania. In the aftermath of the attack, President Bush launches a "war on terror."

2001 Anthrax spores are sent through the mail. They kill five people and sicken 13 others. The culprit or culprits remain unknown.

2001 In October the US and its allies launch air strikes against Afghanistan, and launch a ground offensive a month later. This offensive topples the country's Taliban regime, which is accused of harboring the Al-Qaeda leader Osama bin Laden. Suspected Al-Qaeda members and others are held in the US naval base at Guantánamo Bay, Cuba. They are classified as "illegal combatants," and denied the rights of prisoners of war under the Geneva Convention.

2002 The murder rate falls to its lowest level for 30 years, but gun crime remains high. The US holds more than 2 million people in prison, almost a quarter of the world's total. African-Americans comprise 12 percent of the US population but 44 percent of its prisoners.

2002 WorldCom bankruptcy is the largest-ever corporate collapse.

2002 The Republicans gain firm control of both houses of Congress, allowing the president to push through various controversial policies.

2003 For the second time, a US space shuttle is lost with all its crew as *Discovery* breaks up over Texas while preparing to land.

2003 Austrian-born movie star Arnold Schwarzenegger, a Republican, becomes governor of California.

2003 Bush launches a war against Iraq to overthrow Saddam Hussein, whom he accuses of possessing weapons of mass destruction and of supporting international terrorism. US, UK, and other allied troops occupy the country and hold democratic elections, but a large-scale uprising against the occupation and sectarian violence soon result in a state of near civil war, with rising US and UK casualties. Saddam Hussein is captured, and found guilty by an Iraqi court of crimes against humanity; he is executed in December 2006.

2004 Massachusetts legalizes same-sex marriage. By now several states legally recognize same-sex civil unions or domestic partnerships, but the use of the term "marriage" to describe these is highly controversial.

2004 George W. Bush wins a narrow reelection victory against the Democratic candidate, John Kerry. While Kerry is a Vietnam veteran, a conservative media campaign questioning his wartime service hurts his candidacy, as does the perception among some voters that he doesn't offer a credible plan for ending the conflict in Iraq.

2005 Hurricane Katrina leaves New Orleans devastated, as the city's protective levees are breached. There is widespread criticism of the federal government's slow response to the crisis, which leaves hundreds of thousands of people—most of them poor and African-American—homeless and destitute.

2006 The geographical shift in America's population toward the south and southwest of the country continues, and Arizona now has the fastest growing population in the country. The state capital, Phoenix, is now the fastest-growing city in the US and sprawls over an area larger than Los Angeles.

2006 The Democrats win back control of both houses of Congress as public opinion begins to turn against Bush as the insurgency in Iraq intensifies.

2006 On October 23, at 7:46 a.m. Eastern Time, the 300 millionth American is born somewhere in the country. The population has increased by 50 percent, from 200 million, in the last 39 years. Due to legal and illegal immigration, the percentage of foreign-born Americans is now at least 11 percent nationwide, according to the 2000 Census.

2007 Virginia issues the first official apology for slavery made by any US state. It expresses "profound regret" for slavery and the exploitation of American Indians by white settlers. The apology is all the more important as Virginia was at the heart of the Confederacy during the Civil War.

2007 January: US Representative Nancy Pelosi is sworn in as the first female Speaker of the House of Representatives.

2007 February: Barack Obama, US senator from Illinois, announces he will



Pro-immigration rally

New Yorkers demonstrate in support of immigration reform in March 2007. There are now an estimated 10–12 million illegal immigrants in the US, with the largest percentage from Mexico.

seek the Democratic nomination for president in the 2008 election. With former first lady and current US senator from New York Hillary Clinton also seeking the party's nomination, the upcoming election is widely seen as being the first in US history in which a woman or an African-American stands a good chance of reaching the White House.

2007 April: At Virginia Polytechnic Institute and State University in Blacksburg, Virginia, student Cho Seung Hui uses two handguns to kill 32 people. He commits suicide at the end of the rampage. The massacre is not only the worst school shooting in US history, but also the country's deadliest single episode of gun violence.

2007 April: Dow Jones Industrial Average closes above 13,000 for the first time.

2007 May: Congress approves a \$100 billion spending package to continue financing the war in Iraq. The bill passes without setting a timetable for US withdrawal from Iraq.



Surge in Iraq

Despite widespread political opposition to a continued US presence in Iraq, in January 2007 President Bush committed an additional 22,000 troops in a bid to secure Baghdad from sectarian violence. Here, fresh US troops await deployment.

2008 The United States is hit by its worst economic crisis since the Great Depression as problems in the subprime mortgage market spill over and affect the banking system more generally. The investment bank Lehman Brothers goes bankrupt, while the giant Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac mortgage-underwriting companies are taken under government control. The government pushes through an Economic Stabilization act and guarantees billions of dollars of support for other banks to prevent a complete meltdown of the global banking system.

2009 The Democrat Barack Obama, elected in November 2008, takes office as the 44th president of the United States in January. He is the first African-American to hold such high office. His first priority is the managing of the economic crisis, but he seeks also to mark a change from American foreign policy under George W. Bush by reaching out to Muslim countries, offering a dialogue with Iran. In October he is awarded the Nobel Peace Prize. He pledges an increase in US troop levels in Afghanistan and pushes through a substantial health care reform bill.

2010 In April, an explosion on the Deepwater Horizon oil rig in the Gulf of Mexico, operated by BP, leads to a massive seepage of oil and months of struggle to contain the spill. By the time the well is sealed in September, around 5 million barrels of oil have leaked out. Intense political pressure on BP in the US results in the company pledging a \$20 billion fund to compensate those affected by the disaster.

«236–37 Pilgrim Fathers
«280–81 The Slave Trade
«298–99 American Declaration of Independence
«314–15 The American Civil War
«418–19 The American Dream
«430–31 The Vietnam War
«466–67 9/11